undertaking recruitment decisions, lionize the hero, and expect all problems to be solved once a great man has been appointed. This line of thought is doomed to failure. The primary determinant of policy outcomes is the organization design and not the personnel. Great men also respond to incentives, and pursue their own self-interest: hence, we have repeatedly been disappointed when great men exited a position and we looked back at their report card.

Dispersion of power

Public choice theory and political science emphasize the dangers of concentration of power. Concentrated power will generally be abused for personal gains by the persons wielding the power. This encourages us to disperse power. Mature democracies work by limiting the power of every player in public life. As an example, the United States president has a narrow (‘enumerated’) list of powers under the US Constitution. Unlike the Indian arrangement, the US president does not even control the annual budget, nor does he control the draft legislation that is tabled for discussion by legislators.

It is better to have power dispersed between the three wings of government—the legislative, executive and judicial branches. In this, public choice theory takes us to the same argument as the traditional wisdom of liberal democracy on the value of separation of powers. It is better to organize the state around three branches: the legislature (which enacts the Indian Penal Code), the executive (which investigates crimes and prosecutes some) and the judiciary (which conducts hearings and awards punishments, and is immune to the displeasure of the executive).

It is better to have a bicameral legislature, and different clocks for the selection of representatives in the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha, in order to avoid the possibility of a momentary infatuation of voters inducing concentration of power. In the design of the Constitution of India, voters